

Checklist

Engineering Executive: First 90 Days Checklist

Guiding Principles

- ☐ Prioritize learning over early change
- ☐ Understand systems before modifying them
- ☐ Focus on durable improvements, not visible quick wins
- ☐ Build trust before conflict
- ☐ Move slower than your instincts tell you

1. Clarify Expectations (Week 1–2)

- ☐ Ask your manager (CEO/CTO) to write explicit expectations for your role
- ☐ Ask: *“What will success look like in 6–12 months?”*
- ☐ Identify any urgent, dire issues needing immediate attention
- ☐ Align on measurable goals for your first 90 days

2. Understand the Business

- ☐ Understand how the business makes money
- ☐ Know where money is spent and the current financial runway
- ☐ Identify what must be true in 12 months for step-function growth
- ☐ Identify knowledge gaps between Engineering and the business
- ☐ Learn the company’s core domain deeply

3. Build Relationships & Trust

Listening & Visibility

- ☐ Go on a listening tour (meet individuals and teams)
- ☐ Meet cross-functional peers and stakeholders
- ☐ Set up recurring 1:1s (directs + skip-levels)
- ☐ Share weekly or monthly updates on what you're learning
- ☐ Attend routine forums before changing them

Customer & External Perspective

- ☐ Shadow support tickets
- ☐ Shadow customer/partner meetings
- ☐ Observe user testing sessions

4. Learn How Work Gets Done

- ☐ Map how ideas become shipped work
- ☐ Understand how work is assigned and prioritized
- ☐ Identify who handles emergencies
- ☐ Determine whether execution systems are working and scaling
- ☐ Identify internal Engineering velocity metrics
- ☐ Identify external/business impact metrics

5. Understand Organizational Health

- ☐ Assess team morale and inclusion
- ☐ Identify who is succeeding and who isn't (and why)
- ☐ Document undocumented processes
- ☐ Spot-check compensation and inclusion health
- ☐ Pay attention to non-product engineering roles (e.g., TPM, SRE)

6. Understand the Technology

- ☐ Evaluate whether the existing tech stack is effective
- ☐ Identify major friction points
- ☐ Learn how major technical decisions are made
- ☐ Build and deploy a small, trivial change yourself
- ☐ Join an on-call rotation (as observer if needed)
- ☐ Attend incident reviews
- ☐ Document the technology history and context behind decisions
- ☐ Document the implicit Engineering strategy

7. Understand & Improve Hiring

- ☐ Review hiring funnel metrics and pipeline
- ☐ Establish recurring recruiting meeting (weekly/biweekly)
- ☐ Shadow interviews and onboarding
- ☐ Identify 1-3 highest-priority missing roles
- ☐ Personally help close top candidates
- ☐ Evaluate whether the hiring process needs an overhaul
- ☐ Kick off Engineering brand efforts (blog, talks, social presence)

8. Make the Right (Limited) Changes

- ☐ Limit early changes to 1-2 high-leverage improvements
- ☐ Avoid disrupting systems without a working alternative
- ☐ Consider adding a weekly operational review
- ☐ Evaluate org structure for execution impediments
- ☐ Plan next year's org growth (size, roles, transitions)

9. Learn Through Reflection

- ☐ Follow a “20–40 rule” for problem-solving before asking for help
- ☐ Create a regular thinking space to slow down
- ☐ Avoid rushing to judgment without context
- ☐ Avoid referencing “how we did it at my last job.”
- ☐ Write down what you’re learning

10. Build External Support

- ☐ Build a peer support group of similar leaders
- ☐ Consider engaging an executive coach
- ☐ Create space for self-care (sleep, exercise, therapy, hobbies)

11. Protect Long-Term Sustainability

- ☐ Assess whether team pace is sustainable
- ☐ Identify energy drains (for you and the team)
- ☐ Add energizing practices deliberately
- ☐ Avoid burnout cycles early